SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA

COMMUNITY PERCEPTIONS ON THE SOCIAL REINTEGRATION OF FORMER INMATES

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CHAPTER 1

THE PROBLEM AND ITS SCOPE

1.1 Background of the study

In the Philippines, reintegrating into society can be extremely difficult for ex-offenders, which can make the transfer less successful. These issues have many psychological, social, and economic aspects (Flores, 2019). At the sub-regional level in the country, new changes in how things are run have also helped the continuity between small and large in how criminals are treated. According to a 2019 report by Grace Flores-Barolo, the National Government gave the power to provide basic services to provinces, cities, municipalities, and barangays (villages) through the Local Government Code in 1992. It also gave them the resources, staff, and money they needed. This meant that critical social services were moved from being run by national bodies to being run by local governments. Janer (2019) also said that sharing includes running community-based services and helping families in the local government's area get ahead financially. Consequently, local government units have assumed key roles in addressing poverty among their constituents, fostering peace and order, and promoting socioeconomic development in their regions.

In the United States, the number of people in prison or jail has grown at an unmatched rate over the last 30 years. More than 2.2 million prisoners will eventually be released and rejoin society (Goger et al., 2021). Almost 30 million people are freed from prison around the world every year. A 2020 Research Institute for Crime & Justice Policy report says the United States has the highest imprisonment rate globally. Due to the prison system's size, many offenders are returning to their communities (Annie, 2021). As more inmates are released, a trend that has already

started, they will reenter neighborhoods where there is already a large concentration of returning ex-offenders. People in jail have their lives affected even after they get out (Feingold, 2021).

Anderson et al.'s (2020) study says that when a criminal deals with the criminal justice system for the first time, a process called "community reintegration" starts. Several changes in behavior, social interactions, and thinking happen simultaneously. Several concurrent behavioral, social, and cognitive changes are involved. The study will focus on the significant relationship between the demographic profile of the respondents and the extent of awareness about their challenges, attitudes, and support mechanisms towards former inmates.

The transition process, often called "community reintegration," starts when a criminal first contacts the jail or prison system. There are many changes in how people act, interact with others, and think simultaneously (Haas et al., 2022). One of the main goals of corrections is to help criminals reintegrate into their own group and society. This aligns with what the Bidola et al. (2024) study found. To help people regain their place and function in society, it is essential to help them get back in touch with their family and fit back in with the community once they are released from jail, prison, rehab, or holding centers.

Chairman (2024) asserts that reintegrating into society is often a complex process for ex-offenders. They face several challenges, including stigma, discrimination, and other issues, that increase their chance of recidivism. They have a harder time reintegrating into society because of these barriers. Many ex-offenders can successfully rejoin society and get help from the community, which lets them start over as law-abiding citizens despite these

problems.

While giving people the proper knowledge is essential, one of the main goals of the criminal justice system should be to help offenders get better and rejoin society (Scott et al., 2020). Aftercare programs are vital for assisting people to progress and get back into society after treatment or recovery (Estillore, 2020). Thus, their effectiveness depends on elements like community engagement, ongoing program review, and high-quality training for providers. Aftercare services that are properly handled can lower setbacks and greatly enhance long-term results.

The researchers will look at how different groups in the target area of the study feel about letting former prisoners back into society. In line with the researchers' field of study, criminology, they chose to fill in a gap in the research by finding out how the community views former prisoners, including how much people know about their problems, attitudes, and ways of getting help. Furthermore, the study will assess the community's perception of the reintegration of former inmates in Barangay 9, Purok 3, Buenavista, Agusan del Norte.

The independent variables of the study will be the demographic profile of the respondents, which includes the gender, age, educational attainment, socioeconomic status, and years of residency. Meanwhile, the study's dependent variables include the social acceptance, interpersonal trust, employment reintegration acceptance, support for reintegration programs and reduced stigma that residents face towards former inmates.

The study will employ a quantitative research design. A professional statistician's recommended statistical analysis, mean, frequency, and percentage will be used to analyze additional data. Furthermore, more suggestions will be made after examining the study's future findings and interpreting them. These metrics are intended to gauge how the general public views ex-offenders, focusing on their difficulties, perspectives, and resources for support.

The significance of this study is that it will offer ideal information and research about community perception towards the reintegration of former inmates into the community. Most of us Filipinos viewed ex-convicts as a threat to the community when reintegrated. There is a concern about the probability that an ex-convict may spread a negative influence and impact within the community. Therefore, the researchers will carefully examine the views towards social reintegration of former inmates and the challenges, attitudes, and support mechanisms they encounter.

This study will benefit the community, for it aims to help the community grasp the difficulties faced by ex-convicts as they reintegrate into society, thereby diminishing misconceptions and stigma. This study also helps local governments and government agencies by pointing out negative views. Furthermore, programs can be made to help people accept others, which will make places safer and lower the chance of repeat offenses. Last but not least, this study can be used as a helpful guide by future researchers looking into similar topics, such as community views, social reintegration, and prisoner recovery. We can learn more by comparing the results with other underrepresented groups or in different places with what they show. Similarly, it can help educational institutions identify research gaps, refine methodologies, and develop new frameworks to understand how society can reduce recidivism and promote inclusive development.

1.2 Theoretical Framework

Acknowledging that the community often serves as the setting for offenses or crimes, the community must take on a more significant role in reforming offenders and curbing recidivism. Furthermore, the community and society must be integral in dismantling the psychosocial, economic, and cultural obstacles and other contributing factors to crime in their surroundings to prevent criminal activities, foster peace, and enhance development within the area.

Social Identity Theory

People split themselves and others into "in-groups" (people who are inside) and "out-groups" (people who are outside). People who have been accused of a crime are often seen as outsiders. This can lead to negative views, discrimination, and being rejected by others. It might be harder for them to fit back in because groups might not want to hang out with people who are seen as strangers. These strict boundaries between groups can be broken down with good community involvement programs, public education efforts, and social policies that include everyone. Gradually integrating ex-offenders into society makes communities more tolerant, helpful, and eager to facilitate their successful reintegration (Mikell et. al., 2020).

Social identity theory benefits from prior research because it clarifies why people frequently harbor negative sentiments about ex-offenders. "In-groups" are people people relate to, whereas "out-groups" are people people believe are different. Due to their criminal history, people convicted of a crime are frequently viewed as outsiders. Reintegration is more challenging because this label supports shame, mistrust, and discrimination (Amancio, 2024).

For our study, this theory shows how community members' sense of group identity and connection affects their willingness to help ex-offenders get back into society. It also talks about how awareness campaigns, restorative justice programs, and community support networks can

help ex-offenders go from being seen as "outsiders" to being made to feel like "productive insiders" again (Shields, 2020).

Therefore, this theory backs up the research by demonstrating that community perceptions are not merely personal beliefs but are intricately linked to social classification and group dynamics, directly impacting whether ex-offenders successfully reintegrate into society.

Reintegrative Shaming Theory

This theory originated from Braithwaite (1989). Stigmatizing, shaming, and reintegrative shaming are the two categories of societal reactions to offenders that are distinguished by reintegrative shame theory. People who feel stigmatized cannot connect with others, have negative identities that make it impossible for them to reintegrate, and are forever seen as abnormal. Criminals can return to society with acceptance and respect if they use reintegrative branding. They can still say what they did was bad. This concept is fundamental to this study because it shows how community views affect the rehabilitation of people convicted of a crime. This idea is very relevant to this study because it shows how community views affect the reintegration of former offenders. Reintegrative communities are more likely to have a compassionate attitude toward ex-offenders, which lessens stigma and aids in their rehabilitation. Communities that use stigmatizing shame, on the other hand, keep people out, which can lead to repeat offenses and failed attempts to reintegrate (Akpan et al., 2020).

The Reintegrative Shaming Theory is related to this study because it looks at how community reactions affect the reintegration of former offenders. This theory aims to explain why some communities are more welcoming of ex-offenders than others, and the study focuses on how communities feel about them. The study might help show that caring and accepting

community views can lead to better social reintegration (Elisha, 2023) if we understand these interactions. This shows how excluding and making fun of former criminals can make it harder for them to get back into society and make it more likely that they will commit crimes again. In this way, it shows how stigmatizing and rejecting former criminals might make it harder for them to successfully rejoin society, which could lead to them breaking the law again. Thus, the framework provided by this theory can be used to evaluate the dual role of community perception as a bridge or a barrier to successful reintegration.

In general, these two theories will serve as the basis for data collection to determine if the variables from the study support the hypotheses proposed by the theories used.

1.3 Review of Related Literature

When a criminal goes through the court system, reintegrating them into society starts. Many behavioral, social, and mental changes co-occur (Haas et al., 2022). Additionally, this fits with what Bidola et al. (2024) found; reintegrating prisoners back into their neighborhoods and society is a goal that everyone agrees on in the prison system. Additionally, this means that to help people who have been released from prisons, jails, rehabilitation centers, or detention centers reclaim their roles and places in society, it is essential to assist them as they rejoin the community and build relationships with their families.

From what the Chairman said, it can be hard for people who have been to jail to get back into society. These people are more likely to break the law again because of racism, shame, and other issues. Because of these issues, it is harder for them to get back into society. People in prison can get back into society and get help from the community. This helps them start over as law-abiding citizens even though there are some problems.

A big goal of the criminal justice system should be to help convicts get better and rejoin society, along with giving them accurate information (Scott et al., 2020). Aftercare programs are crucial for assisting people to keep progressing and integrate back into society after treatment or recovery (Estillore, 2020). Accordingly, how well they work relies on getting the community involved, reviewing the programs regularly, and giving providers good training. Providing the right kind of aftercare services can cut down on failures and make long-term results much better.

Age

People's views on the social reintegration of ex-offenders can be significantly affected by their age, as can their values, experiences, and social contacts. Teenagers and young adults exposed to modern media and schooling may support rehabilitation and the idea of second chances (Jackson, 2020). Because of this, they might believe in restorative justice and see readmission as a fundamental human right. They may have a more positive view of recovery because they may not have been directly affected by crime as much.

The 2023 study by Vivares shows that middle-aged people put their families and neighborhoods first. They might only help ex-offenders get back into society if there is sound proof that programs that help people get better work. While some may understand the challenges faced by former inmates trying to reintegrate into society, others might cling to negative stereotypes caused by fears linked to crime (Ruvheneko Mental Health Advocates Foundation, 023). Therefore, middle-aged residents support reintegration under certain conditions, provided they are assured that precautions are in place.

Punishment may be more important to older generations than rehabilitation. They can think that a person is a lifelong criminal (Moore, 018). These people may be against reintegrating formerly incarcerated people into their communities because they are more concerned about

security. A lack of acceptance may result from older persons' inability to change firmly held views (Staff, 020). As a result, older inhabitants are more likely to be skeptical or resistant due to conventional viewpoints and anxieties about crime.

Educational attainment

Pagan's research from 2022 shows that the level of education of people has a significant effect on how they feel about former prisoners returning to society. People with less schooling tend to have stronger stereotypes about ex-convicts and see them as possible threats to public safety. However, people with only a high school education often have mixed feelings and only support reintegration regarding job opportunities or tight supervision. Tunetv (2021), on the other hand, found that people with more education are more likely to be open and helpful because they know more about social justice, recovery, and why people commit crimes. As people learn more, they tend to have more positive and accepting views on reentry.

The level of schooling of ex-offenders' families and communities also has a significant effect on their ability to get back into society. This includes their chances of getting a job, acceptance, and the shame of having a criminal record (Mowen, 2018). Communities with higher education tend to foster greater empathy and understanding, which helps diminish ex-offenders' challenges when looking for jobs, housing, and social acceptance. On the other hand, communities with low education can sustain negative perceptions and a cycle of exclusion, making it more difficult for former convicts to achieve independence and reintegrate successfully into society (Pathinayake, 2019).

Individuals with Low Educational Attainment (Elementary or below) may have limited familiarity with restorative justice principles. They are more inclined to depend on stereotypes and may view ex-convicts as ongoing dangers to community safety (Apolinarion, 2022).

Those with Moderate Educational Attainment (High School to some College) may have varying opinions; some may endorse reintegration if it is linked to job opportunities, livelihood, or strict oversight. Personal or community encounters with crime often influence their views (Gabon et. al., 2023)

Due to their exposure to concepts like social justice, human rights, and rehabilitation, people with higher educational attainment who have completed college or above tend to be more sympathetic and empathetic. They frequently acknowledge the root causes of crime, such as poverty, a lack of education, and social inequity. They are more inclined to support social programs, training, and employment possibilities for ex-offenders (Llantos et al., 2023).

Gender

Men and women may have different perspectives on risks and societal roles; gender can have an impact on how ex-offenders are perceived to be reintegrating into society (Mashau, 2023).

Male residents may take a more pragmatic stance, with some being more receptive to reintegration since they believe in giving second chances, particularly when they view ex-offenders as valuable workforce members (Chen et al., 2020). Nevertheless, specific individuals might perceive ex-convicts as rivals or sources of potential danger, particularly regarding safety and job prospects (Khoshnami et. al., 2021).

In contrast to the study of Liem (2018), female residents often express more apprehension and worry about safety, particularly when it comes to their families and children, which may lead them to be more reluctant to accept ex-convicts into their neighborhoods. Simultaneously, women may exhibit heightened empathy and understanding, supporting reintegrating efforts linked to rehabilitation, job training programs, and community safety measures.

The conclusion drawn from the literature in relation to our study is that gender has a significant impact on public perceptions of ex-offenders' reintegration. Women may be more skeptical of or uninterested in parole than men, which could be due to safety concerns or protective impulses. At the same time, female offenders who are reentering society frequently face problems like trauma, mental health issues, and caregiving responsibilities that differ from those faced by their male counterparts and influence how the public views them.

Socioeconomic status

Mathlin et. al. (2022) pointed out that residents' socioeconomic status has a significant influence on how they feel about ex-offenders being reintegrated. Some people may be more hesitant because they have personal experience with poverty, but others may be more reluctant because they fear increased crime or competition for jobs. Although middle-class residents often have conflicting views, they support reintegration as long as it improves community stability and safety. However, because they have been exposed to rehabilitation and social justice principles more frequently, members of higher socioeconomic categories are generally more accepting; however, their support may be conditioned on maintaining their personal safety and way of life (Jones et al., 2022). Accordingly, perceptions generally become more favourable and encouraging as socioeconomic position increases.

Lokenga et al. (2023) emphasized that socioeconomic position considerably impacts how the general public views ex-offenders' social reintegration. When criminal activity is connected to poverty or marginalization, communities with lower socioeconomic standing tend to see ex-offenders through a prism of stigma and stereotypes, seeing them as social and economic threats. Systemic problems, including unemployment, unstable housing, and a lack of social support, further exacerbate this resistance.

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On the other hand, communities that experience effective reintegration, which is defined by social or familial support and economic stability, generally exhibit greater acceptance (Chirrman, 2024). Significantly, support for reintegration also depends on residents' views regarding human potential; individuals who adopt a growth mindset are more inclined to support reentry, regardless of their economic situation. At the same time, symbolic barriers and fears related to resource competition create further psychological and social obstacles within lower socioeconomic contexts (Mori et. al., 2024).

In general, public perceptions of ex-convict reintegration are heavily influenced by socioeconomic status. People from low-SES homes face many problems, such as not having enough legal help and getting harsher sentences, as well as the deep-seated shame and social exclusion that come with being poor. Mental Health Advocates Foundation (2023) says that communities often see ex-convicts from low-income homes as threats or moral failures

because these deeply rooted systemic and cultural problems are linked to social identity and structural realities.

Bernabe's study from 2024 says that having strong social ties and stable finances can help people feel good about reintegration. This supports what the experts said in the relevant literature. Beliefs about development mindsets or the just-world can change people's attitudes, regardless of their social or economic rank. Furthermore, perceptions and the desire to reintegrate ex-offenders into society are further shaped by the interaction of SES, race, and community context.

Years of residency

The length of time that people have lived in a community may impact their views regarding ex-offenders' reintegration. Newcomers tend to be more accepting and less critical because they have less money and experience in the area; their opinions are more influenced by general society views than personal experiences (Muleya, 2021). However, because they prioritize safety, tradition, and stability and frequently associate ex-offenders with dangers or negative experiences from the past, long-term residents who have close links to the community might be less eager (Palgan, M. D., & Apolinario, 2022). People who have lived there for a moderate period of time tend to have more complex opinions, according to Tagle et al. (2023). They support reintegration when I maintain peace, but they become wary when safety issues arise

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Neighborhood researchers (Buck et al., 2021) discovered that the length of time residents have lived in a neighborhood, a crucial measure of residential stability, influences their social networks, sense of group efficacy, and fear of crime, all of which have an impact on how people feel about reintegrating ex-offenders. Strong informal control and many social connections can deter criminal activity and create a sense of exclusivity in long-standing groups. As a result, unless reintegration programs maintain order and benefit the community, long-term residents are less inclined to trust them.

According to Cochran et al. (2021), the length of time living in a place and owning a home are also linked to fear about crime and social cohesion, which are essential factors that affect acceptance. Higher levels of fear lower support, while close communities may support reintegration if it improves safety and consistency.

In conclusion, community case studies show that long-term residents are more likely to share local stories and talk about their experiences with returning citizens. This can change people's views about whether to back or oppose the move.

Social acceptance

Social acceptance is one of the most widely recognized determinants of successful reintegration for formerly incarcerated individuals. A large-scale review on reintegration outcomes found that community acceptance consistently predicts lower recidivism and smoother reintegration transitions, especially when community members express openness and supportive attitudes toward returning citizens (Berg & Huebner, 2022). Similarly, a study in Europe demonstrated that individuals released from custody reintegrate more effectively when local residents perceive reintegration as a shared community responsibility rather than a threat to social order (Maschi et al., 2021). These findings indicate that social acceptance forms a foundation upon which long-term reintegration success is built.

In various international contexts, qualitative studies highlight how acceptance from neighbors, family networks, and faith-based communities reduces psychological distress and increases feelings of belonging among former inmates. For instance, Harding et al. (2022) reported that returning citizens commonly describe acceptance as a crucial component of their post-release well-being. Likewise, Chui and Cheng (2021) found that when communities express supportive attitudes, former offenders experience improved emotional stability and greater motivation to desist from crime. These studies show that social acceptance influences both practical reintegration outcomes and internal identity restoration.

Research also suggests that acceptance within the community directly interacts with other reintegration indicators, such as housing stability and employment opportunities. Visher and Lattimore (2020) noted that social support from community members often facilitates access to resources and reduces structural barriers. In addition, Abrahams et al. (2023) demonstrated that communities that adopt reintegrative practices rather than exclusionary or punitive attitudes encourage positive behaviors and reduce marginalization. This implies that social acceptance is not a passive condition but an active process that shapes reintegration trajectories.

In relevance to the study, measuring social acceptance allows you to identify whether the local community perceives reintegration positively and whether returning citizens are socially welcomed. This variable captures attitudes and behaviors that influence reintegration beyond formal programs, aligning with global findings that acceptance is a core social determinant of long-term reintegration success (Visher & Lattimore, 2020).

Interpersonal Trust

Interpersonal trust plays a critical role in shaping reintegration experiences, as trust between community members and former offenders affects daily interactions and social inclusion. According to Jackson and Tyler (2021), trust significantly influences whether individuals believe returning citizens deserve second chances, impacting neighborhood cooperation and perceptions of safety. In a multi-country analysis, Noda and Fernandes (2022) found that higher interpersonal trust is associated with more supportive attitudes toward reintegration efforts, suggesting that community members who trust others generally show greater openness toward formerly incarcerated persons.

Several qualitative studies indicate that many individuals leaving prison struggle with the perception that community members view them with suspicion or guardedness. Martínez-García et al. (2025) reported that former inmates often describe reintegration as emotionally challenging due to perceived mistrust from neighbors and peers. This feeling of being distrusted creates barriers to building new relationships and accessing support networks. Meanwhile, Davis et al. (2020) found that successful reintegration is often dependent on the presence of "trust brokers"—community leaders, mentors, or organizations who vouch for former inmates and help rebuild trust between them and the community.

Interpersonal trust has also been linked to broader social structures such as neighborhood cohesion and collective efficacy. Farrall and Hunter (2021) found that communities exhibiting high levels of internal trust tend to be more accepting of reintegration initiatives. Similarly, Harding et al. (2022) observed that trust mediates the relationship between community safety perceptions and reintegration success, meaning that trust can soften concerns about crime while enhancing community cooperation.

In relation to the study, interpersonal trust is essential for understanding how community members evaluate and interact with former offenders in your study setting. Trust influences whether community members believe returning citizens can safely participate in communal life, access opportunities, or belong to social networks. Measuring interpersonal trust allows your study to identify hidden psychological or relational barriers that influence reintegration outcomes a factor consistently highlighted in global reintegration research (Jackson & Tyler, 2021; Noda & Fernandes, 2022).

Employment Reintegration Acceptance

Employment reintegration acceptance is widely recognized as a core component of successful reentry, as communities and employers play a critical role in determining whether former offenders can rebuild stable lives post-release. Duwe (2020) emphasizes that employment improves financial stability, strengthens self-efficacy, and reduces recidivism, but these benefits rely heavily on community willingness to hire returning citizens. In a global comparative study, Harding et al. (2022) found that labor market discrimination continues to be one of the most persistent barriers to reintegration, particularly in communities where stigma against incarceration remains strong. Acceptance from employers is therefore not merely an economic matter it is a key social determinant of reintegration.

Several studies show that employers' attitudes are strongly shaped by perceptions of risk and trustworthiness. Bucknor and Barber (2021) report that employers who believe in rehabilitation or have previous positive experiences with hiring former inmates demonstrate significantly higher acceptance. Likewise, Attewell and Gustafson (2020) found that when employers are educated on reintegration outcomes and supported through reintegration programs, they become more open to fair-chance hiring practices. These findings highlight that acceptance is dynamic and can increase when communities receive accurate information about reentry.

Recent research also shows that community-level support influences whether former inmates are able to secure stable work. Visher and Lattimore (2020) found that communities with higher overall acceptance toward reintegration tend to foster better employment outcomes, as social networks often link returning citizens to job opportunities. Similarly, Berg and Huebner

(2022) emphasize that informal community networks neighborhood contacts, local organizations, and faith groups can help overcome structural barriers when formal employers remain hesitant.

In relevance to the study, employment acceptance is critical in the Philippine setting because many local communities rely on small businesses, informal labor systems, and interpersonal relationships for job opportunities. By examining employment reintegration acceptance, your study can identify whether local residents and employers are supportive of allowing former inmates to work in the community and whether social stigma still limits their access to livelihood opportunities. This aligns with global evidence that employment acceptance is a cornerstone of sustainable reintegration (Duwe, 2020; Harding et al., 2022).

Support for Reintegration Programs

Community support for reintegration programs such as livelihood programs, counseling, monitoring, and community-based initiatives has been shown to significantly enhance reentry outcomes. Pettus-Davis et al. (2020) found that reintegration programs rooted in community support reduce the risk of reoffending by improving social stability and access to services. Likewise, Grommon and Rydberg (2021) identified that communities demonstrating strong program support tend to report lower levels of fear of crime and greater cooperation in reintegration efforts. These findings show that reintegration programs rely not only on institutional design but also on community endorsement.

Studies in the U.S., Europe, and Southeast Asia alike highlight that community engagement determines the success of many reintegration initiatives. Rahim et al. (2022) found that culturally informed community support systems increase program participation among returning citizens and reduce negative perceptions of reintegration initiatives. Similarly, Deuchar

and Sapouna (2021) observed that when communities collaborate with reintegration agencies, returning citizens report smoother transitions and stronger pro-social relationships.

More recent research emphasizes the importance of multi-stakeholder partnerships between government agencies, civil society, and community groups. Maschi et al. (2021) argue that reintegration programs succeed when communities recognize their shared responsibility in reintegration rather than placing the burden solely on the justice system. Visher and Lattimore (2020) likewise note that supportive communities improve program adherence and help promote long-term distance.

Therefore, support for reintegration programs reveals whether the community values and collaborates with the policies that govern the reintegration of former inmates. This variable helps identify not only community attitudes but also the level of participation in reintegration activities a critical factor in determining whether reintegration programs can function effectively at the barangay level. This aligns with international evidence that community support is essential for successful reentry (Pettus-Davis et al., 2020).

Reduced Stigma

Reduced stigma is consistently identified as a decisive factor influencing reintegration outcomes. Stigma affects social relationships, employment opportunities, housing access, and mental health among returning citizens. Tyler and Jackson (2021) found that stigma reduction significantly increases community trust and willingness to interact with former offenders. Similarly, Kılıç and Tuysuz (2024) demonstrated that positive community contact and structured reintegration programs reduce negative stereotypes and promote social acceptance. These findings illustrate how stigma directly shapes reintegration experiences.

Stigma also affects reintegration across different cultural contexts. Noda and Fernandes (2022) observed that in communities with strong collectivist values, stigma reduction plays an even more important role, as social perceptions heavily influence individual opportunities. Furthermore, Martínez-García et al. (2025) found that many former inmates feel socially judged upon release, and this judgment creates emotional distress that undermines reintegration. Their study shows that stigma operates both externally (community views) and internally (self-stigma).

Additional literature highlights stigma's impact on practical reintegration outcomes. Harding et al. (2022) argue that communities with low stigma levels show higher reintegration success due to improved access to employment and social networks. Abrahams et al. (2023) also found that reducing stigma enhances community safety because returning citizens with positive social acceptance are less likely to return to crime. Together, these studies indicate that stigma reduction is a powerful intervention point for policy and practice.

Therefore, reduced stigma is a critical variable in your study because stigma directly influences community attitudes, trust levels, and opportunities for former inmates. Measuring stigma reduction will enable you to determine whether local residents view returning citizens as capable of change or continue to associate them with criminal behavior. Consistent with global findings, stigma reduction is a key predictor of reintegration success (Tyler & Jackson, 2021; Kılıç & Tuysuz, 2024).

1.4 Schematic Diagram

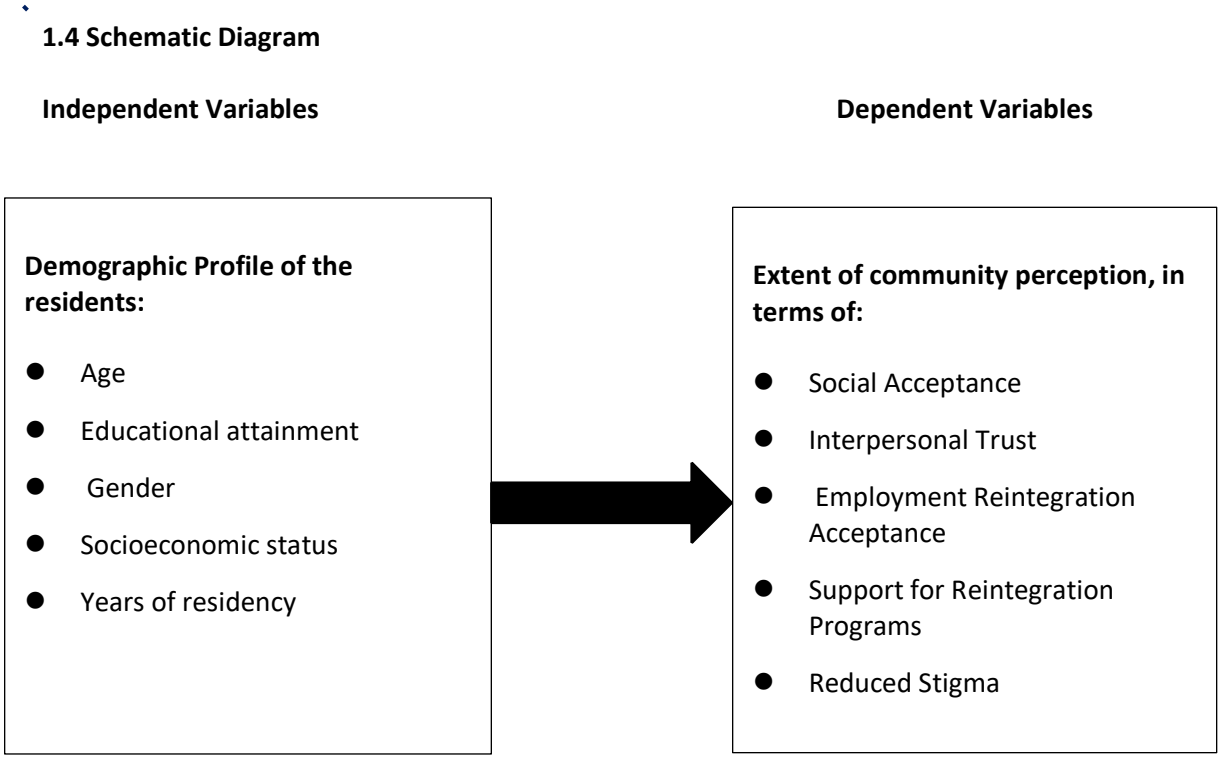


Figure 1. The diagram shows the interplay between the Independent and Dependent variables of the study.

1.5 Statement of the Problem/ Objectives of the Study

The study will assess the extent of the community's perception of the reintegration of former inmates in Brgy. 9, Malpoc, Macalang and Sacol, Buenavista Agusan del Norte.

It seeks to answer the following questions:

1. What is the demographic profile of the residents in terms of:

    1.1 Age;

    1.2 Gender;

    1.3 Educational attainment;

    1.4 Socioeconomic status; and

    1.5 Years of residency?

2. What is the extent of the community's perception of the reintegration of former inmates, in terms of:

    2.1 Social Acceptance;

    2.2 Interpersonal Trust;

    2.3 Employment Reintegration Acceptance;

    2.4 Support for Reintegration Programs; and

    2.5 Reduced Stigma?

3. Is there a significant relationship between the demographic profile of the residents and the extent of the community's perception of the reintegration of former inmates in the selected barangays of Buenavista, Agusan del Norte?

1.6 Hypothesis

Ho1: There is no significant relationship between the demographic profile of the residents and the extent of the community's perception of the reintegration of former inmates in the selected barangays of Buenavista, Agusan del Norte.

1.7 Definition of Terms

The terms will be operationally defined based on their use in this study.

Age. Refers to the years a resident exists.

Gender. Refers to whether residents are male or female.

Educational attainment. Refers to the highest educational background a resident has attained.

Socioeconomic status. Refers to the level of income a household earns monthly.

Years of residency. Refers to the length of residency in a specific location.

Social Acceptance. Refers to the Willingness to interact or socialize with former inmates.

Interpersonal Trust. Refers to trusting former inmates in daily life and community roles.

Employment Reintegration Acceptance. Refers to openness to hiring or working with former inmates.

Support for Reintegration Programs. Refers to the agreement that the community should support livelihood, aftercare, and training programs.

Reduced Stigma. Refers to a Lower tendency to discriminate or judge former inmates.

Scope and Limitation

The study will be conducted in Buenavista. It will be limited mainly to the selected Barangay residents where ex-convicts are reintegrated. This study focuses on the extent of community perception towards ex-inmates' community reintegration, and will be conducted in the academic year 2025-2026.

CHAPTER 2

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

2.1 Research Design

The researchers will use a quantitative research design. This method provides objective and measurable data on community perceptions towards the social reintegration of former inmates. Additionally, researchers will employ the survey-evaluation method, specifically the Likert Scale, to assess aspects that provide an evidence-based evaluation of dependent variables across demographic profiles.

A population sample will be surveyed, and the results will be used to extrapolate to the entire population. The researchers will use a survey, employing questionnaires and sampling procedures to gather public opinion or individual characteristics (Jackson, 2015).

2.2 Research Materials and Methods

The researchers will use a self-made survey questionnaire that aligns to the study's objective. The questionnaire will be validated by professionals . Questions that will be used will compensate for the independent and dependent variables of the study.

2.3 Research Environment, Population, and Sample

The study will be conducted among the residents of Barangay 9 in Buenavista, Agusan del Norte.

A total population of 2488 residents in Barangay 9, Malpoc, Macalang and Sacol Buenavista, Agusan Del Norte.

The researchers will have a total sample of 334 residents for the survey. Stratified random sampling will gather data from the total sample per the study's objective.

Table 1. Respondents of the Study

Barangay	Population			Sample					
	Male	Female	Total	Male		Female		Total	
	F	F	F	f	%	f	%	f	%
Barangay 9	370	382	752	50	15.0	52	15.6	102	30.5
Barangay Malpoc	301	300	601	40	12.0	40	12.0	80	24.0
Barangay Macalang	170	142	312	23	6.9	19	5.7	42	12.6
Barangay Sacol	413	410	823	55	16.5	55	16.5	110	32.9
Total	1254	1234	2488	168	50.3	166	49.7	334	100.0

2.4 Research Data and Analysis Plan

The following steps will be taken to gather the data:

At first, the researchers will write a letter requesting approval containing the study's purpose and the Distribution of Informed Consent form. The data will be gathered by using direct survey firms.

Second, the researchers will present the informed consent form to the respondents. It will be an agreement that the respondents understood and exercised their rights to agree and disagree to answer the question.

Third, respondents will be given a set of survey questionnaires and a list of questions prepared by the researchers, which will be validated by the experts and answered by each respondent.

Lastly, for the respondents, the researchers will give a consent form and state first the purpose of the study to the selected respondents, the freedom to withdraw anytime they like, and then emphasize that the detailed information given out will be strictly confidential and can

only be accessed by the researchers. The researchers will apply the statistical treatment, analysis, and interpretation when granted authorization.

Statistical Treatment

The researchers will employ the following statistical techniques to analyze the data effectively. The percentage is the tool used to clarify the data.

Frequency and Percentage. It will answer problem 1 in computing the frequency and percentage of the demographic profile of residents.

Mean. It will answer problem number 2 in determining the extent of community perception towards the social reintegration of former inmates.

Pearson's R Correlational. This tool will address SOP 3, which examines the significant relationship between the demographic profile of residents and the extent of community perception towards the social reintegration of former inmates.

2.5 Research Ethical Standards

This study will be conducted per established ethical research standards and institutional protocols.

A. Intellectual Property Rights (IPR)

The researchers were fully protected by their intellectual property rights throughout the research process. The study's data, material, and resources, such as papers, publications, and electronic data, were properly credited and acknowledged to give credit to the original authors. The research excludes plagiarism, unappreciated usage, and patent or copyright infringement. All software, frameworks, and tools used for data analysis were open-source, properly licensed, or used with the owners' consent.

B. Informed Consent

"Community Perceptions on the Social Reintegration of Former Inmates: Challenges, Attitudes, and Support Mechanisms" required informed consent as a primary ethical foundation. Before their involvement, the participants received sufficient information on the study's significance, procedures, goals, and purpose. To ensure they participated willingly, participants were informed of the potential dangers and rewards, and their written agreement was requested. Additionally, the members were assured that their involvement was entirely optional and that they would not be penalized for ceasing at any moment.

C. Data Privacy and Confidentiality

The fair selection of participants was ensured by choosing individuals directly relevant to the study's objectives, particularly community members and stakeholders with insights or experiences related to the social reintegration of former inmates. This approach upholds justice by including participants whose perspectives accurately represent community attitudes, challenges, and support mechanisms.

D. Voluntary Participation and Freedom to Withdraw

The current study was entirely voluntary. The volunteers were free to decide whether to participate in the survey. Additionally, they were informed of their freedom to leave the learning process without facing any negative repercussions. In this sense, every volunteer consented and was well informed of their rights.

E. Minimization of Harm and Risk Management

The researchers took great caution to minimize any possible danger or pain to the volunteers. Participants were advised that no personally or institutionally identifiable information would be disclosed because the topic is cybersecurity threats that may unintentionally straddle the boundaries of delicate organizational issues. The study avoided questions that would cause

stress, embarrassment, or damage one's reputation. All interactions were courteous and professional, and it was encouraged to respond comfortably.

F. Beneficence and Contribution to Knowledge

The purpose of this study was to impact society and the academic community. Communities should enhance their understanding and support systems for the social reintegration of former inmates. The study contributes to social development by highlighting real-life challenges, public attitudes, and the importance of community-based support mechanisms that promote successful reintegration and reduce stigma.

G. Justice and Fair Participant Selection

The fair selection of participants was ensured by choosing individuals directly relevant to the study's objectives, particularly community members and stakeholders with insights or experiences related to the social reintegration of former inmates. This approach upholds justice by including participants whose perspectives accurately represent community attitudes, challenges, and support mechanisms. The selection process for participants was inclusive and aimed to minimize bias or discrimination based on gender, role, or institution. Due to equal participation opportunities for all eligible citizens, this method upheld the ethical trusteeship of justice.

H. Data Integrity and Accuracy

Standardized procedures were used to collect and analyze data to maintain the findings' validity and dependability. The report's authors continuously made great pains to guarantee that the information gathered from the observations was accurately and consistently recorded. To

preserve academic integrity and draw reliable conclusions, one must freely recognize and declare any potential biases, restrictions, or misunderstandings.

I. Transparency and Honesty in Reporting

To prevent plagiarism, the researchers committed to reporting all findings truthfully, regardless of whether they confirmed the original hypotheses. All information, literature, and materials used in the study were cited correctly and credited. This dedication to truthfulness improves the study's credibility and allows other researchers or practitioners to confirm the results.

J. Use of Patented or Copyrighted Materials

Every copyrighted and patentable resource used in this study, including published papers, software, and digital tools, was properly cited or used with consent when required. The researchers obtained permission before using or reproducing any intellectual property belonging to others. Regarding open-source resources, the researchers respect academic and legal norms while acknowledging that they are still actively employed in research.

K. Considerations for Human Subjects

Human subjects were treated with dignity, fairness, and respect throughout the research process. To explicitly safeguard the participants, ethical measures were put in place to guarantee their welfare, right to privacy, and rights as study participants, all covered by the ethics Saint Michael College of Caraga has authorized. No personal identifiers were gathered during the data collection process to ensure anonymity.

L. Responsible Use of AI and Other Technologies

To achieve and maintain the integrity of the data while preserving its authenticity, any artificial intelligence (AI) technologies or digital platforms utilized in the data analysis,

transcription, or organization process were employed responsibly. Researchers used human judgment to confirm AI-assisted results in each instance and avoided prejudice, data manipulation, or ethical transgressions.

M. Ethical Clearance and Institutional Approval

Ethical Clearance and Institutional Approval: The Saint Michael College of Caraga Ethics Review Committee provided ethical clearance and approval before the research study's execution. The study adhered to the national data privacy law, the institution's moral standards, and the international ethics in research approach. This guaranteed that the study project moved forward with professionalism, academic integrity, and transparency.

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